50TH ANNIVERSARY

1995-2005

THE GREAT CHURN

The time of flourishing was at hand. A faster, richer life beckoned all around: gleaming expressways, digital autobahns, small and big screens lit up by desire, an abundance of choice on supermarket shelves, phone-a-friend at the click of a button. But if the world was now closer, serenity was still far away. On the surface, India's visage was scarred by conflict, its brow deepened in worry. A roll of the nuclear dice did not abolish the chance of war. Guns rattled on the border and in the heart of the Republic. Like a perverse game of tic tac toe, riots and terror followed every attempt at peace. Chaos and fragmentation appeared to precede order in the polity as governments came in and went out. But in the end, it was all a creative burst, the labour pangs of a new India. The kaleidoscope was experimenting with its future patterns.